



NITI Aayog



SECTOR AT A GLANCE 09

Urban: Menstrual Hygiene Management

WASH in India

DRAFT

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URBAN: MENSTRUAL HYGIENE MANAGEMENT

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The '**Sector-at-a-Glance**' provides an easy-to-read overview and basic understanding of a sector, sub-sector, or thematic area. The facts and insights on the sector are supported by relevant data and best practices from credible government and multilateral sources. The document covers the structure, key trends, opportunities and challenges, government initiatives, and the way forward for the sector.

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Overview

Menstrual hygiene management (MHM) refers to access to safe menstrual materials, accurate information, and facilities for washing, waste management, and bathing during menstruation.¹ Good MHM enables women and girls to manage their menstruation safely, with dignity, and without discomfort or infection.²

Adopting effective menstrual health management practices can ensure the health, well-being, education, and livelihoods of women and girls. This is accomplished through improved access to MHM products, school and workplace MHM interventions, and increased awareness efforts.

In urban India, access to menstrual hygiene products and facilities is better than in rural areas.³ However, challenges related to awareness, and quality of services impede safe MHM for poor and marginalized girls and women. Lack of sanitation, clean water, incinerators and sanitary pad dispensers affects the MHM of urban slum dwellers and migrants living in temporary settlements. There is also a pressing need to raise awareness and knowledge about MHM, particularly among adolescents.

Given these opportunities and challenges, improving sanitation infrastructure, enhancing access to affordable and hygienic absorbents, and awareness building are the major policy focus areas. Several ongoing and recent central government initiatives, such as the National Urban Sanitation Policy and Swachh Bharat Mission Urban, focus on providing hygienic and affordable sanitation facilities for urban poor and women. They also prioritize efficient management of solid and liquid waste in cities and towns. These efforts, along with several state- and local-level policies and initiatives, seek to ensure that all menstruating Indian women and girls experience safe, healthy, and stigma-free menstruation.

This note covers key statistics, challenges and opportunities, as well as some ideas for the way forward in improving MHM outcomes in rural India.

Figure 1: Key Menstrual hygiene management statistics

71%

Adolescent girls are unaware of menstrual until they experience it

2.3 crores

Girls drop out of school each year due to lack of period education and protection

89%

Urban women aged 15-24 years use hygienic menstrual products

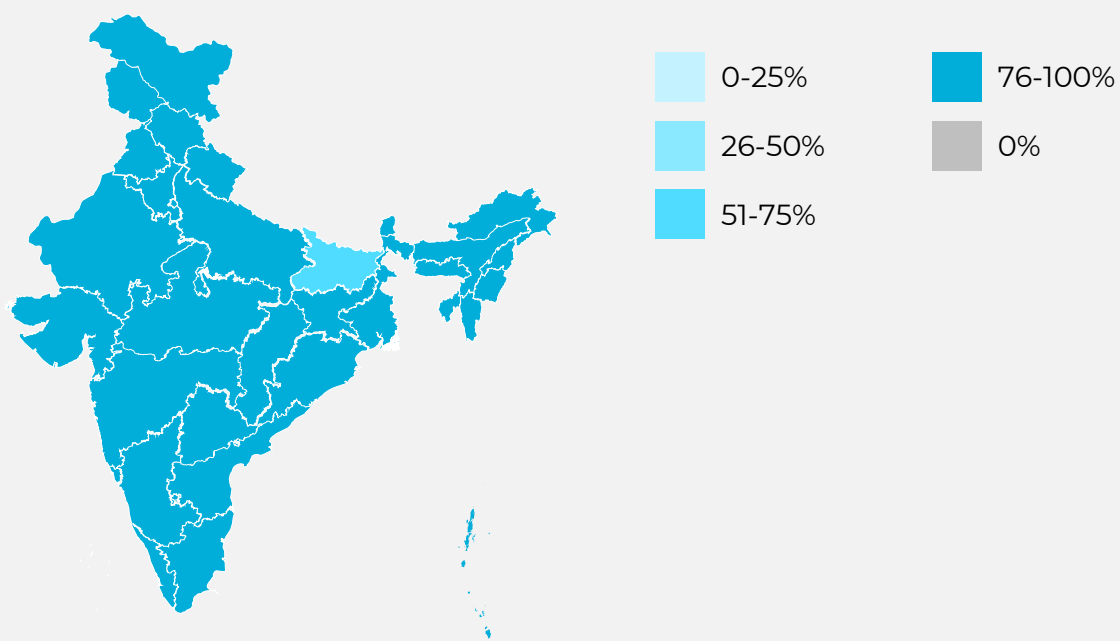
Source: UNICEF, Changing the future with lessons from the past, accessed August 2023; UNESCO, UNESCO Joins Whisper®'s mission to #KeepGirlsInSchool to ensure girls don't miss out on a promising future, 2021; Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5) 2019-21, 2021

¹ UNICEF, Guidance on Menstrual Health and Hygiene, 2019

² UNICEF, Guidance on Menstrual Health and Hygiene, 2019

³ Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey 5.0, 2019-2021

Figure 2: Share of urban women aged 15-24 years using hygienic methods of protection during their menstrual period (2019-20)



Source: Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5) 2019-21, 2021

Opportunities and challenges

Opportunities

This section highlights the outcomes policymakers can achieve by adopting effective menstrual hygiene management practices in urban regions. These revolve primarily around improvement in reproductive health outcomes, educational outcomes, and increased productivity.



Improvement in reproductive health outcomes:

Women and girls with better MHM knowledge are less likely to be vulnerable to adverse reproductive health outcomes, which include reproductive tract infections and fertility issues.⁴ Moreover, with improved access to safe and affordable sanitary materials, the risk of infections is further reduced. This also improves overall reproductive and sexual health, including maternal outcomes, lower teen pregnancy, and improved fertility.⁵



Improvement in educational outcomes:

As per UNESCO, 23 million girls drop out of school in India each year due to a lack of period education and protection.⁶ Implementing school-level interventions through adolescent health education and sensitization programs covering menstruation and puberty can improve knowledge and help tackle stigma.⁷



Increase in workplace productivity:

Inadequate menstrual health and hygiene pose a great challenge for working women, affecting their productivity, job satisfaction, attendance, and advancement.⁸ A growing body of research shows that inclusive menstrual facilities and policies improve company retention and performance and foster employee appreciation and commitment.⁹



Increase in awareness at the slum level:

Urban slums present several challenges to women and girls—from the burdens of urban poverty to lack of familial support and privacy, poor infrastructure, and so on.¹⁰ Conducting health outreach in slums to provide information and subsidized sanitary products can promote awareness among the masses and access to menstrual products for women and girls.¹¹ Moreover, by ramping up the local infrastructure by installing accessible community or SHE toilets and incinerators, MHM practices can be improved significantly.

Challenges

This section highlights some of the major challenges and constraints facing urban menstrual hygiene management in India. Efforts to resolve such challenges will ensure higher access to menstrual hygiene-related facilities, alongside greater social awareness.

4 National Institute of Public Cooperation and Child Development, Improvement in Knowledge and Practices of Adolescent Girls Regarding Reproductive Health with Special Emphasis on Hygiene during Menstruation in Five Years, 2014

5 World Bank, Menstrual Health and Hygiene, 2022

6 UNESCO, UNESCO Joins Whisper's mission to #KeepGirlsInSchool to ensure girls don't miss out on a promising future, 2021

7 IJSR, Impact of Structured Education Regarding Menstrual Hygiene Practices among Adolescent Girls, 2014

8 Journal of Water, Sanitation and Hygiene for Development, Building a business case for workplace menstrual hygiene management programs: a social cost-benefit analysis, 2023

9 Period Positive Workplace, Becoming a Period Positive Workplace is good for business, accessed 2023; USAID, Menstrual Hygiene Management and Women's Economic Empowerment: A Review of Existing Evidence, 2019

10 Indian Journal of Gender Studies, Does Menstrual Hygiene Management in Urban Slums Need a Different Lens? Challenges Faced by Women and Girls in Jaipur and Delhi, 2019

11 UN, Promoting awareness among women in the slums of Bangalore (India) on usage of Sanitary napkins instead of unclean piece of cloth during the period of menstruation, accessed 2023



Limited sanitation infrastructure:

Women and adolescent girls residing in urban slums face specific vulnerabilities concerning menstruation due to restricted access to safe and private spaces with water for changing, washing, bathing, and laundering reusable pads or menstrual cloth.¹² Additionally, they lack sufficient access to culturally acceptable and adequate disposal mechanisms for used menstrual materials.¹³



Limited access to appropriate menstrual products:

Around 11% of urban women aged 15-24 years use unhygienic methods of protection during menstruation.¹⁴ Financial constraints and poverty are primary drivers for this, alongside a lack of affordable menstrual products or gaps in supply. Thus, among the 355 MN menstruators in India, 12% cannot afford period products.¹⁵



Restrictive social norms and taboos:

Taboos and myths continue to hinder the optimal use of the 8,000-plus Adolescents-Friendly Health Clinics (AFHCs) set up by the government nationwide.¹⁶ Socio-cultural norms that consider periods impure contribute to women's and adolescent girls' social isolation. Awareness gaps and misconceptions hinder open discussions about safe menstrual practices among parents, teachers, and other community members.¹⁷



Insufficient awareness about MHM:

Hygienic methods of disposal of menstrual waste are not followed widely in urban India as well, highlighting the scope for improving awareness among women and girls.¹⁸ Moreover, awareness of men on MHM in India is low. Emphasising the role of men in MHM could unlock strong psycho-social support for menstruating women and girls and create an enabling environment to address their needs.¹⁹

Institutional framework and policy landscape –

Key ministries and departments

This section highlights the major central government bodies and national-level institutions that oversee urban menstrual hygiene management.



Ministry of Health and Family Welfare

The Ministry which operates through its two departments- the Department of Health & Family Welfare and the Department of Health Research, aims to ensure the availability of quality healthcare on an equitable, accessible and affordable basis across India. Issues related to improving menstrual hygiene management in urban India also fall under its ambit.²⁰

12 Sarah J Goddard and Marni Sommer, Menstrual Health and Hygiene Management and WASH in Urban Slums: Gaps in the Evidence and Recommendations, 2020

13 Sarah J Goddard and Marni Sommer, Menstrual Health and Hygiene Management and WASH in Urban Slums: Gaps in the Evidence and Recommendations, 2020

14 Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey, 2019-20

15 World Bank, Menstrual health and hygiene empowers women and girls: How to ensure we get it right, 2021

16 Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Menstrual Health in India: An Update, 2017; Reproductive Health Journal, Measuring adolescent friendly health services in India: A scoping review of evaluations, 2016

17 MoHFW, Menstrual Health in India: An Update, 2019

18 Ministry of Jal Shakti, Menstrual Hygiene Management, accessed August 2023; MoHFW, Menstrual Health in India: An Update, 2019

19 UNICEF, Menstrual Hygiene Management Programming in Maharashtra, accessed August 2023

20 Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Vision, Mission and Objective Statement of MoHFW, 2019

Department of School Education and Literacy

The Department which is housed under the Ministry of Education seeks to create a quality education system, particularly focusing on disadvantaged groups, thereby promoting economic and social mobility, inclusion, and equality. Promoting sound menstrual hygiene practices for girls is also included as one of the focus areas.²¹

Ministry of Woman and Child Development

The Ministry seeks to promote the socio-economic empowerment of women through policies and programmes, mainstream gender concerns, generate awareness about their rights and facilitate institutional support for enabling women to actualise their potential. Initiatives around promoting sound menstrual hygiene management in urban India also fall under its ambit.²²

Major policies and programs

This section highlights existing policies related to urban menstrual hygiene management and their most prominent features. A more comprehensive list of policies is provided in the policy repository of the NITI for States platform.

Draft National Menstrual Hygiene Policy, 2023

This policy aims to ensure that every person who menstruates has access to safe appropriate menstrual hygiene resources thereby improving their quality of life. Primary focus areas include menstrual hygiene products and facilities, quality standards and regulatory framework, awareness and education, research and innovation in menstrual hygiene management, and the like.²³

Scheme for Promotion of Menstrual Hygiene:

This scheme which has been running since 2011 aims to increase awareness among adolescent girls, to ensure greater access to and use of high-quality sanitary napkins, alongside ensuring safe disposal of these. This also includes the orientation of teachers, frontline Workers- Auxiliary Nurse Midwives (FLW-ANMs), Accredited Social Health Activist (ASHA) workers and Anganwadi Workers (AWWs).²⁴

Samagra Shiksha:

The Department of School Education and Literacy implements this integrated scheme under which state-specific projects for interventions on menstrual health and hygiene, including the installation of sanitary pad vending machines and incinerators are sanctioned.²⁵

Mission Shakti:

Under the Beti Bachao Beti Padhao (BBBP) component of 'Mission Shakti' which is an integrated women empowerment programme, special focus is given to menstrual hygiene, with one of the objectives being the generation of awareness about menstrual hygiene and the use of sanitary napkins.²⁶

21 Department of School Education and Literacy, About School Education & Literacy, accessed December 2023

22 Ministry of Women and Child Development, Year End Review-2022: Ministry of Women and Child Development, 2022

23 Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Draft Menstrual Hygiene Policy, 2023

24 Ministry of Women and Child Development, Menstrual Hygiene Practices, 2023

25 Ministry of Women and Child Development, Menstrual Hygiene Practices, 2023

26 Ministry of Women and Child Development, Menstrual Hygiene Practices, 2023

Way forward

India has made significant strides in advancing menstrual hygiene management outcomes in recent years through large-scale awareness drives and policy initiatives. However, substantial gaps remain in product access, social attitudes, infrastructure and monitoring mechanisms - especially for marginalized communities and the urban poor.

Some ideas that could accelerate progress going forward include:

 Sustaining IEC campaigns	Mass media campaigns, especially in vernacular languages, can help transform social attitudes and demystify menstruation. Such messaging should also target men to make them supportive allies.
 Advancing menstrual hygiene in schools	Ensuring access to menstrual products and private washing facilities in urban schools via centralized budgets, accompanied by monitoring mechanisms for proper usage, can ensure effective menstrual health management for adolescent girls.
 Tailoring community outreach	Customizing community outreach programs and product distribution strategies can help better reach vulnerable groups like slum dwellers, migrants, and the homeless by addressing their unique constraints.
 Supporting inclusive product innovation	Promoting startups innovating eco-friendly product designs and decentralized waste management solutions specific to urban areas through incentives, and providing omni-channel access for these products, particularly in densely populated areas or high traffic tourist/urban areas
 Promoting menstrual-friendly workplaces	Institutionalizing workplace policies on private resting areas and proper disposal mechanisms through policy guidelines and awareness drives targeting corporates.

Recommended readings

Ministry of Health and Family Welfare. (2023). *Draft Menstrual Hygiene Policy 2023*.

<https://main.mohfw.gov.in/sites/default/files/Draft%20Menstrual%20Hygiene%20Policy%202023%20-For%20Comments.pdf>

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<https://pib.gov.in/PressReleaselframePage.aspx?PRID=1945842>

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UNFPA and WaterAid. (2021). *Landscape of Menstrual Products in India*.

<https://www.wateraid.org/in/sites/g/files/jkxoof336/files/2022-03/Designed%20Version%20-%20Menstrual%20Product%20Landscape.pdf>

UNFPA and WaterAid. (2021). *Strengthening the supply chain of menstrual hygiene products in India*.

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UNICEF. (2019). *Guidance on Menstrual Health and Hygiene*

<https://www.unicef.org/media/91341/file/UNICEF-Guidance-menstrual-health-hygiene-2019.pdf>

MoHFW. (2019). *Menstrual Health in India: An Update*

https://pdf.usaid.gov/pdf_docs/PA00W863.pdf



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